FREQUENCY STABILITY WITH HIGH RENEWABLE PENETRATION

Safayetul Chowdhury
M.Eng, University of Calgary
UCID-30219728,Group-05

Asif Rahman
M.Eng, University of Calgary
UCID-30248137,Group-05

Shafkat Haque
M.Eng, University of Calgary
UCID-30262437,Group -05

***Abstract*— With the growing penetration of renewable energy sources, overall power system inertia is expected to decline because conventional synchronous generators—such as thermal and hydro units—are being displaced by wind and solar resources. This reduction in rotational inertia weakens the system's ability to maintain stable frequency, leading to greater frequency deviations following contingencies. Therefore, this paper examines how decreasing inertia impacts frequency response in renewable-integrated power systems. It begins by reviewing the critical inertia thresholds identified in various systems, including requirements related to ROCOF, synchronous inertia, and non-synchronous penetration levels by studying various papers**.

Keywords—RES, frequency stability, ROCOF, inertia constant, synchronous generation.

Introduction

A major challenge associated with high penetration of renewable energy sources (RES) in microgrids is the significant reduction of system inertia. In conventional power systems, inertia is supplied by the rotating masses of synchronous generators, whose stored kinetic energy naturally damps frequency variations and supports overall frequency stability. In contrast, RES units do not provide inherent inertia because they interface with the grid through power electronic converters. As renewable integration increases, the total system inertia declines, making the grid more susceptible to frequency instability. During disturbances, this reduced inertia leads to faster frequency changes and larger frequency deviations, increasing the risk of instability.[1]

I. PROBLEM STATEMENT

Power system inertia refers to the system's inherent ability to resist changes in frequency, provided by the kinetic energy stored in the rotating masses of synchronously connected generators and motor loads. The total inertia available at any moment depends on the amount of energy stored in these rotating machines. As more non-synchronous, inverter-based resources such as wind, solar, and battery systems replace conventional synchronous generators—particularly during low-demand periods—the overall synchronous inertia of the grid inevitably decreases.

Inertia plays a key role in determining the initial Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF) following a sudden generation loss. When system inertia is low, RoCoF becomes larger, reducing the available time for frequency control mechanisms to respond and preventing frequency from dropping below under-frequency load-shedding thresholds. This increases the risk of automatic and unintentional load disconnection.[2][3]

Synchronous generators and motors naturally release kinetic energy when a disturbance occurs, slowing down as they supply this energy to the grid. This immediate contribution, known as inertial response, slows the initial frequency decline and is critical for system reliability in the first moments after a generation trip.

II. LITERATURE REVIEW

A central theme across the literature on modern power systems is the fundamental role of inertia in maintaining frequency stability, but each paper approaches this topic with different depth, modeling techniques, and perspectives. The NREL report *Inertia and the Power Grid: A Guide Without the Spin* provides the clearest conceptual explanation of inertia, describing it as the kinetic energy stored in synchronous generators that naturally opposes sudden frequency deviations [4]
. This report uses intuitive analogies—such as comparing inertial response to a vehicle coasting—to make the concept approachable for policymakers and readers without technical backgrounds. By contrast, the ERCOT technical document offers a more operational definition, framing inertia as a measurable system attribute determined by the inertia constants and MVA ratings of online synchronous machines, with direct implications for RoCoF and system protection settings [5]
. Meanwhile, the academic study by Wu et al. extends the definition further by highlighting that inverter-based renewable energy sources inherently lack physical rotating mass, making them incapable of contributing synchronous inertia without additional control strategies such as synthetic inertia or virtual inertia algorithms [2]. This divergence in framing—conceptual in NREL, operational in ERCOT, and technical in academic research—illustrates the multifaceted nature of inertia as both a physical phenomenon and a system operator's engineering constraint.
As renewable penetration rises, all sources agree that system inertia will decline, but they differ in how they quantify and analyze the consequences. ERCOT provides real operational evidence that high wind penetration correlates with low system inertia periods, particularly during low-load hours when synchronous units are economically displaced. It identifies a critical synchronous inertia threshold of approximately 105 GW·s required to keep RoCoF within acceptable limits to avoid triggering under-frequency load

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shedding (UFLS) before primary frequency response activates [5]. NREL similarly emphasizes the vulnerability of low-inertia conditions, showing frequency traces where systems with reduced inertia experience sharper and faster frequency drops, leaving minimal time for governors and other control mechanisms to respond. The NREL report goes further by explaining the nuanced interplay between inertia, primary frequency response, contingency size, system load, and protection thresholds, supported by graphical analysis and scenario-based simulations [4]. In contrast, Wu et al. adopt a modeling-based perspective, using PMU measurements from Taiwan to calibrate single-bus frequency response models that quantify the relationship between renewable penetration and higher RoCoF, deeper nadirs, and reduced stabilization times. Their work demonstrates mathematically how increasing RES penetration causes non-linear deterioration of frequency metrics, making system stability increasingly fragile [2]. Zhao et al. extend this analytical approach further by proposing a comprehensive assessment method using the system's equivalent inertia time constant, enabling quantification of inertia under scenarios when synchronous plants are fully or partially replaced by renewables. Their IEEE 30-bus system simulations show near-linear declines in equivalent inertia time constant as RES penetration increases, directly linking these declines to elevated RoCoF and stability risks [3]. Thus, while ERCOT provides empirical operational data, NREL provides system-wide conceptual demonstrations, and the academic papers provide mathematical and modeling rigor.

These different perspectives also lead to diverse approaches for modeling and evaluating frequency stability in low-inertia systems. NREL's analysis uses simplified conceptual models to illustrate how inertia interacts with governor response, UFLS thresholds, and contingency magnitudes. Its graphical depictions (e.g., system frequency vs. time charts) highlight the qualitative importance of inertia in buying the grid time to initiate corrective responses [4]. ERCOT's approach is more pragmatic: it uses historical data and worst-case contingency analysis to establish minimum inertia requirements and outline operational constraints. Rather than proposing new modeling techniques, ERCOT focuses on practical thresholds that system operators must observe, such as the necessity to curtail wind generation or commit synchronous units when inertia falls below safe limits. In contrast, Wu et al. and Zhao et al. rely on mathematical models to quantify inertia and predict system behavior. Wu et al.'s single-bus frequency response model uses real grid measurements to capture dynamic interplay between inertia, PFR, and RES output, offering a data-driven approach that can be adapted to real-time stability monitoring [2]

. Zhao et al. present a more structural and formulaic methodology, using the equivalent inertia time constant to assess frequency stability, compute inertia indexes, and determine safe renewable penetration limits. Their contribution is particularly important because it offers a system-agnostic method that can be applied to different grid configurations, making it useful for planning future grids with high renewable shares . Thus, the four papers contribute complementary modeling approaches—conceptual, operational, data-driven, and mathematical—filling different parts of the analytical landscape.

The literature also reveals differences in how the papers propose solutions to declining inertia. NREL discusses a wide spectrum of mitigation strategies—including fast frequency response (FFR), synthetic inertia, and the transformative potential of grid-forming inverters—arguing that inverter-based resources can actually reduce the amount of inertia required if equipped with sufficiently fast and sophisticated controls . This reflects an emerging paradigm: rather than replacing lost inertia with physical spinning mass, future grids may rely on electronically controlled responses that react much faster than traditional governors. ERCOT, on the other hand, focuses on pragmatic and currently deployed solutions. It highlights the introduction of Fast Frequency Response services, reliance on responsive loads, and operational limits on non-synchronous penetration. It does not speculate heavily on future technologies but instead concentrates on tools already validated in real-world grid operations. Wu et al. approach the problem from the perspective of evaluating how RES could provide synthetic inertia and fast active power adjustments through control algorithms, although they caution that such responses require careful tuning and may have limited energy capacity depending on turbine operating states [2][4][5][6]. Zhao et al. also discuss mitigation, but emphasize system-level planning: their inertia assessment methodology is designed to help planners identify safe RES penetration levels, design inertia support strategies, and determine when additional synchronous condensers, battery storage, or grid-forming inverters are required.

Across the four papers, a clear pattern of complementarity emerges. NREL offers a conceptual and future-oriented perspective, ERCOT provides real-world operational insights, Wu et al. contribute empirical modeling based on actual PMU data, and Zhao et al. provide a theoretical assessment framework using inertia time constants. Several topics appear in multiple papers but are treated differently—for example, RoCoF is described qualitatively by NREL, operationally constrained in ERCOT, empirically measured by Wu et al., and mathematically embedded in Zhao et al.'s assessment indexes. These differing treatments enrich the literature, showing both the universality of the challenges and the variety of tools available to address them. Collectively, the papers provide a comprehensive view of the evolving frequency stability landscape: inertia is declining due to renewable integration, but through accurate modeling, operational planning, and emerging technologies such as fast frequency response and grid-forming inverters, power systems can remain reliable even in extremely low-inertia conditions.

III. Critical discussion

A. Methods, definitions and concept:

Frequency stability describes a power system's ability to maintain its nominal frequency during normal operating conditions and to recover effectively after a disturbance or imbalance. Events such as the sudden loss of generation or the abrupt disconnection of loads can cause deviations in system frequency. In these moments, system inertia plays a vital role by resisting rapid frequency changes and providing

the critical time needed for corrective control actions to engage.

Inertia originates from synchronous generators and motors, which store kinetic energy in their rotating masses. When generation suddenly drops, electrical demand exceeds available supply, and the system immediately draws on the kinetic energy of all online synchronous machines. As these machines release stored energy, their rotational speed decreases, resulting in an observable drop in system frequency. This immediate and automatic behavior is known as the inertial response. It is essential during the first instants after a disturbance because it slows the initial frequency decline and allows mechanisms such as primary frequency response to activate before the system reaches critical thresholds.

1. Frequency Stability and Its Control Mechanisms

Frequency stability represents the capability of a power system to maintain its nominal frequency during normal operating conditions and to withstand, arrest, and recover from disturbances that introduce generation–demand imbalances. Following disturbance such as a sudden loss of generation, system frequency begins to decline. The system's ability to limit this deviation—particularly the initial rate of change of frequency (RoCoF), the frequency nadir, and the subsequent restoration to nominal conditions—depends on a coordinated sequence of stabilizing mechanisms.

1.1 Inertial Response (0–2 seconds)

Immediately after disturbance, synchronous generators inherently release the kinetic energy stored in their rotating masses. This energy injection occurs without any external control action and provides the fastest response available in the system. The inertial response slows the initial frequency decline, thereby reducing RoCoF and providing a critical temporal buffer for slower control processes to activate. As highlighted in the NREL report, this inertial behavior forms the first layer of defense, effectively "buying time" for primary and secondary frequency control mechanisms to respond.

1.2 Primary Frequency Response (PFR) (2–30 seconds)

Once frequency deviation is detected, the turbine governors of synchronous generators begin to adjust mechanical input power. This primary frequency response increases generation proportionally to the magnitude of the frequency drop, helping arrest the decline and contributing to the recovery toward a stable operating point. Due to mechanical and aerodynamic limitations of turbines, PFR evolves more slowly than the inertial response, typically delivering between 0.3% and 2% of additional power per second. Although slower, PFR is essential for lifting frequency from its nadir and preventing deeper instability

A practical way to quantify system inertia is through the equivalent inertia constant, H (in seconds), which expresses the ratio of the total kinetic energy stored in the rotating masses to the rated apparent power of the system:

$$H = \frac{E_k}{S_{\text{rated}}}$$

where

E_k = total kinetic energy of all rotating machines (MJ),
S_{rated} = system rated power (MVA).

Another key indicator of frequency stability is the Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF), defined as df/dt. RoCoF reflects how rapidly the frequency changes immediately following a disturbance—before any control or protection system responds. It provides a direct measure of the severity of the power imbalance. The instantaneous RoCoF just after a disturbance can be expressed as:

$$\text{RoCoF}\,|_{t=0^+} = \frac{\Delta P_{\text{imbalance}}}{S_{\text{base}}} \cdot \frac{f_0}{2H}$$

The level of system inertia directly affects this initial RoCoF value: higher inertia slows the rate of frequency decline and improves overall system resilience, while lower inertia results in a steeper RoCoF and increases the risk of instability

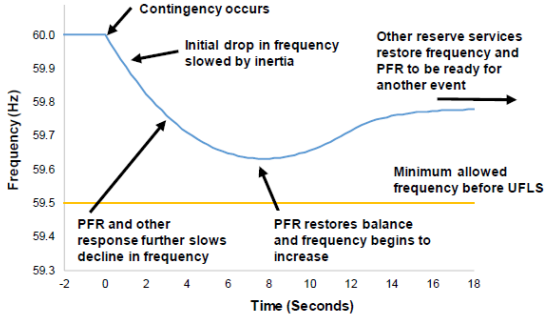


Figure 01: A typical recovery from a contingency event[4]

System inertia determines how quickly system frequency changes immediately after a disturbance such as a generator trip or a sudden increase in load. When inertia is low, the resulting Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF) becomes much steeper. A high RoCoF causes frequency to fall so rapidly that conventional frequency response mechanisms may not have sufficient time to activate before the frequency approaches under-frequency load-shedding limits. If this happens, portions of customer load may be unintentionally disconnected to protect the system. The term *critical inertia* refers to the minimum level of inertia required to ensure that fast frequency response resources can act quickly enough to halt the frequency decline—preventing it from dropping past 59.3 Hz during a major generation loss event.

B. Case study based on reference paper:[3]

The system's equivalent inertia constant after replacing a portion of conventional generators with renewable energy sources is given by:

$$H_r = \frac{S_L H_L + S_{n+1} H_{n+1} + \cdots + S_N H_N}{S_{\text{sys}}},$$

where $S_L, S_{n+1}, \ldots, S_N$ represent the power ratings of the remaining synchronous generators, $H_L, H_{n+1}, \ldots, H_N$ are their corresponding inertia constants, and S_{sys} denotes the total generation capacity of the system. When renewable energy units displace conventional synchronous machines, the effective inertia decreases in proportion to the renewable penetration factor η, which is expressed as:

$$H_r = H_r(1-\eta),$$

where η quantifies the share of renewable generation contributing to inertia reduction.

The Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF) following a disturbance is linked to the system's inertia and the size of the imbalance. It is computed as:

$$\text{RoCoF}_{\max} = \frac{\Delta P_e \, f}{2H_r S},$$

where ΔP_e is the magnitude of the power imbalance in megawatts, and H_r is the reduced equivalent inertia after renewable integration.

To evaluate system adequacy, the inertia assessment index is defined as:

$$\lambda_H = \frac{H_r - H_{\text{cr}}}{H_T - H_{\text{cr}}},$$

where H_T is the original inertia of the system, H_r is the inertia after renewables are introduced, and H_{cr} represents the minimum critical inertia required to prevent under-frequency load shedding.

A complementary RoCoF assessment index is given by:

$$\lambda_{\text{RoCoF}} = \frac{\text{RoCoF}_{\max} - \text{RoCoF}}{\text{RoCoF}_{\max}},$$

which measures how close the system is to exceeding acceptable RoCoF limits.

These indicators, together with the frequency deviation margin index λ_{ad}, form a comprehensive stability index:

$$\delta = \lambda_H \lambda_{\text{RoCoF}} \lambda_{\text{ad}},$$

where the deviation margin is defined as:

$$\lambda_{\text{ad}} = \frac{f_{\min} - f_{\text{cr}}}{f_r - f_{\text{cr}}},$$

with $f_{\min}$ being the minimum frequency following a disturbance, f_r the nominal system frequency, and f_{cr} the critical security threshold.

The overall stability condition is determined by the sign of δ:

- $\delta > 0$ indicates a stable and secure frequency response,
- $\delta < 0$ denotes instability and insufficient frequency resilience, and
- $\delta = 0$ marks the boundary condition at which the system is critically stable [3]

C. Result discussion:

In this study, a three-scenario analysis was conducted to evaluate the system inertia assessment index under varying levels of renewable energy penetration. The system under consideration has a total installed generation capacity of 425 MW and a load demand of 285 MW, with all generating units initially operating as conventional synchronous machines. A disturbance of 45 MW is applied at $t = 5$ s. Using the defined equations, renewable penetration levels of 0%, 25%, and 50% were examined to determine their impact on frequency stability.

The comprehensive assessment index δ was used as the primary indicator of system security. A negative value ($\delta < 0$) signifies that the system is unstable and does not meet the minimum frequency security requirements. Higher values of δ correspond to improved stability, indicating that the system possesses sufficient inertia and frequency response capability under the examined operating conditions. Similarly, the Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF) is also used as a stability measure: larger RoCoF stability index values indicate better system resilience. Overall, the results demonstrate how increasing renewable penetration reduces system inertia and weakens stability, while higher δ and RoCoF-related index values reflect improved dynamic performance.

η(%)	0.00	25.00	50.00
Hr(s)	6.50	4.87	3.25
RoCoF(Hz/s)	0.51	0.68	1.03
λ_h	1.00	0.49	-0.03
λRoCof	0.49	0.32	-0.03
λnadir	0.49	0.09	-1.05
δ	0.23	0.01	0.00

Table1: A table containing assessment index at different RE penetration

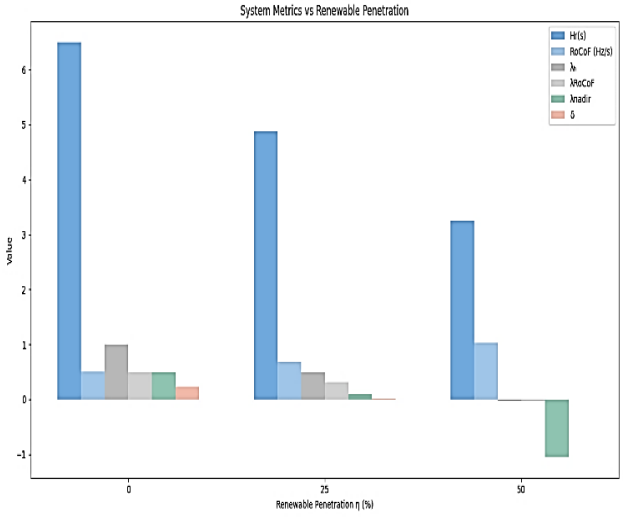


FIGURE 02: DIFFERENT ASSESMENT INDEX AT VARIOUS RE PENETRATION LEVEL

IV. FUTURE DIRECTION

As power systems move toward very high, and eventually near-100%, renewable energy penetration, ensuring frequency stability will require new approaches that do not depend on traditional synchronous inertia. Emerging technologies—such as grid-forming inverters, synthetic inertia, fast energy storage, and hybrid stability solutions—show that renewable-heavy grids can remain stable even with little or no synchronous generation. However, further research, development, and large-scale implementation are still needed before these solutions can be fully deployed across national grids.

A major direction for future work is the wider use of grid-forming (GFM) inverters [4][5], which can create and regulate voltage and frequency without relying on synchronous generators. Although they are already used successfully in small microgrids, expanding them to large power systems is more complex. Challenges include coordinating many GFMs, maintaining stability during faults, and developing decentralized control strategies that work without fast communication links. Future studies must identify standard GFM control methods, determine the right balance between grid-forming and grid-following inverters, and validate these approaches through pilot projects and real-world demonstrations.At the same time, synthetic inertia and fast frequency response (FFR) [8] must continue to advance. Unlike mechanical inertia, synthetic inertia is fully programmable and can be tuned to system needs, allowing renewable plants to act like synchronous machines. Future improvements should focus on adaptive controls that adjust synthetic inertia depending on grid conditions, more reliable disturbance detection, and managing the limited energy available in wind turbines during frequency events. Clear performance standards will also be necessary so different manufacturers and grid operators can apply synthetic inertia consistently.

Battery Energy Storage Systems (BESS) [4][5] will be essential for future low-inertia grids. Because batteries can respond within milliseconds, they are effective at stopping frequency decline before nadir. Research should examine how to coordinate BESS for multiple functions—such as inertia support, primary frequency response, and energy balancing—and how to design market incentives that encourage storage owners to provide stability services. Co-locating batteries with wind or solar plants will also increase their ability to support the grid during renewable variability. Flywheel energy storage provides another valuable tool, offering real mechanical inertia and instantaneous response. Future work may combine flywheels with batteries to create hybrid systems that provide both rapid and longer-duration support. Studies will be needed to determine the best mix of physical inertia (from flywheels or synchronous condensers) and synthetic inertia (from GFM inverters and BESS) at different renewable penetration levels.

Going forward, grid planners will need to design hybrid stability architectures in which grid-forming inverters, synthetic inertia, and fast energy storage replace many roles previously served by synchronous machines. Instead of relying on high inertia, future systems will depend on fast detection, rapid power injection, and coordinated inverter control. This shift requires updating protection systems, RoCoF limits, and operational standards to match the faster frequency dynamics of inverter-based grids.

Economic studies will also become increasingly important. Researchers must estimate the cost of implementing GFM inverters, synthetic inertia, and storage-based support at large scale. Regulators will need to create market frameworks that reward these new services appropriately. It also remains to be seen whether future grids will rely entirely on inverter-based technologies or maintain a small share of synchronous condensers or modified generators for added security.

In summary, the future of renewable integration depends not on preserving traditional inertia but on adopting fast, programmable, and coordinated inverter-based stability systems. With continued innovation in grid-forming controls, synthetic inertia, and energy storage technologies, it will be possible to achieve high renewable penetration without sacrificing reliability. The key challenge now is developing the standards, control frameworks, and planning methods needed to implement these solutions on large power systems

V. Conclusion

This paper examined the growing challenge of maintaining frequency stability in power systems with high renewable energy penetration. As conventional synchronous generators are displaced by inverter-based renewable sources such as wind and solar, system inertia decreases significantly. Since inertia governs the initial Rate of Change of Frequency (RoCoF) during disturbances, lower inertia results in faster and deeper frequency deviations, reducing the time available for traditional frequency control mechanisms to respond. Through a detailed literature review, this study showed how different organizations and researchers characterize inertia—from conceptual explanations by NREL, to operational thresholds defined by ERCOT, to analytical modeling approaches developed in academic studies. Together, these perspectives highlight both the severity of the inertia decline and the emerging tools available to mitigate its impact.

A case study with three renewable penetration levels (0%, 25%, and 50%) was used to evaluate system performance using equivalent inertia, RoCoF, and a comprehensive stability index (δ) [3]. The results confirmed that increasing renewable penetration weakens system stability: δ decreased from 0.23 at 0% penetration to nearly zero at 50%, indicating a transition from secure operation to critical or unstable conditions. Steeper RoCoF values further illustrated the system's reduced ability to withstand disturbances without corrective action.Despite these challenges, the study emphasizes that high renewable penetration does not inherently compromise frequency stability. Emerging technologies such as grid-forming inverters, synthetic inertia, fast-responding battery storage, and flywheels offer rapid and programmable frequency support that can compensate for reduced mechanical inertia. These technologies can form the foundation of future hybrid stability architectures capable of ensuring secure operation even with minimal synchronous generation.Overall, maintaining frequency stability in renewable-rich grids will require coordinated advances in control strategies, system planning, operational standards, and market mechanisms. With these innovations, power systems can reliably transition to high or even 100% renewable energy penetration.

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